be read in one sitting. These poems are generally about Italian figures from different classes of the society. Their passions, adventures and tensions create a lot of interest: they do touch upon issues of morality and psychology but Browning takes them in his stride and does not let us feel disturbed. This cheerful spirit of Browning has endeared him to modern poets though his poems are considered to be difficult on account of wide-ranging allusions.

17.2 ROBERT BROWNING: LIFE AND WORKS

Robert Browning was born in 1812. His father worked in the Bank of England and was a man of literary interests. He had a vast collection of books in his personal library. Robert Browning's mother was a nice musician. It was natural for Robert Browning to be interested in literature and music. Before he entered University College, London he had acquired proficiency in French, Italian, Greek and Latin. However, he left the college without a degree.

In his youth Browning was greatly influenced by Shelley – his poetry and his atheism. He did not remain an atheist for long but he continued to be a radical like Shelley. In 1845, Browning met Elizabeth Barrett in London. When her father objected to their marriage, they eloped to Italy, the country that fascinated Browning.

Browning had started writing quite early. His first published work was a long poem – **Pauline** in which he tried to imitate Shelley's style. He attracted critical attention by **Men and Women** in 1855. **The Ring and The Book** is an ambitious poem of his in which he justified the ways of God through extended blank verse monologues. These were greatly admired by Ezra Pound and T.S. Eliot.

His dramatic monologues portray a great variety of characters speaking to a silent listener about themselves at some important moment in their lives. It is not actually what they say that is important, more important are the things which they do not speak of directly but which are revealed through their tone and the implications of what they think and do. Browning died in 1889 and was buried in Westminster Abbey.

Major Works

Pauline	1833
Parcelsus	1835
Men and women	1855
Dramatic Personae	1864
The Ring and The Book	1869
Asolando	1889

Self-check Exercise I

1) What impression of Robert Browning do you have after learning the facts of his life?

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